



Julie Collins MP

Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry

Ref: MS25-900067

Ms Victoria Anderson
Secretary
Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry
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Dear Secretary

I am writing to acknowledge the important work of the Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry (the department) to lead the Australian Government's efforts to support, protect and grow Australia's agricultural sector – the agricultural, fisheries, forestry, food and fibre industries.

As outlined in the *Regulator Performance Resource Management Guide 128* (RMG 128)¹ the department is accountable to Parliament, including through Senate Estimates and the Australian National Audit Office scrutiny on its regulatory operations. Clear expectations from Government to regulators help drive better regulator performance through best practice.

Consistent with RMG 128, I have enclosed the Ministerial Statement of Expectations (SOE) which outlines the principles I expect the department to demonstrate through its regulatory operations. I would appreciate your response to this letter, as soon as practicable in 2026, in the form of a Statement of Intent (SOI) outlining how these expectations will be delivered by the department.

To ensure transparency and accountability, the SOE and SOI should be made publicly available on your website. The statements should also be integrated into your performance processes as required under the *Public Governance, Performance and Accountability Act 2013* as part of your corporate planning process and annual reporting.

Yours sincerely

Julie Collins MP

22/12/2025

Enc. Ministerial Statement of Expectations

¹ Available on the Department of Finance's [website](#), Regulator Performance (RMG 128)

Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry Statement of Expectations

Improving Australia's productivity performance is a key priority for the Australian Government. In an increasingly complex and interconnected environment, regulation and regulators play a critical role in supporting Australia's productivity through the effective management of risk, enabling innovation, and ensuring protections for Australians.

This Statement of Expectations (SOE) reflects the government's commitment to best practice regulation, as outlined in *Regulator Performance Resource Management Guide 128* (RMG 128), and the policy objective for Commonwealth regulators to strengthen productivity in Australia by taking a more proportionate risk-based approach to regulation to better balance risk mitigation with efficiency, growth and dynamism as a priority, and consider the impact on productivity of all their regulatory activities.

I expect the department to enhance regulatory efficiency by reducing red tape, easing regulatory burden for business and encouraging investment across the agricultural, fisheries and forestry industries (the agricultural sector).

This SOE is informed by the *Regulatory Policy, Practice and Performance Framework*², the Australian Public Service (APS) Reform Agenda, and the outcomes of the Economic Reform Roundtable (August 2025). It complements the department's obligations under the *Public Governance, Performance and Accountability Act 2013* (PGPA Act) and aligns with the government's broader regulatory reform and productivity agenda.

Regulatory responsibilities

The work of the department in its regulatory functions supports the significant contribution of Australia's agricultural, fishery and forestry sectors to Australia's economy. The department plays a critical role in contributing to Australia's health and economic prosperity by developing and promoting sustainable agricultural production practices, certifying and assuring agricultural exports to ensure trade and market access, maximising economic opportunities for our First Nations peoples, and keeping Australians safe through effective biosecurity.

The department is expected to undertake the following regulatory functions in the public interest while continuing to safeguard and grow sustainable agriculture, fisheries and forestry for all Australians:

- assessing and managing biosecurity risks and risks relating to ballast water as the Director of Biosecurity pursuant to the *Biosecurity Act 2015* and associated charging legislation

² Available on the Department of Finance's [website](#), Whole-of-government Regulatory Policy, Practice & Performance Framework

- regulating goods for export pursuant to the *Export Control Act 2020* and associated charging legislation
- prohibiting the importation of illegally logged timber and the processing of illegally logged domestic raw logs as regulator pursuant to the *Illegal Logging Prohibition Act 2012* and associated Rules
- ensuring food imported into Australia complies with Australian food standards and public health and safety requirements pursuant to the *Imported Food Control Act 1992* and associated charging legislation
- administering primary industry levy and charges collection and disbursement pursuant to the *Primary Industries Levies and Charge Collection Act 2024* and the *Primary Industry Levies and Charges Disbursement Act 2024* and associated imposition legislation.

These regulatory functions must be delivered in a way that supports productivity, minimises the regulatory burden, and maintains public trust. They should also be delivered by using mechanisms pre, at and post border, and by working collaboratively with government, industry and community stakeholders, including First Nations peoples and relevant international regulatory bodies.

Regulatory reform and productivity agenda

The government's regulatory reform agenda is central to boosting Australia's productivity by reducing unnecessary or duplicative regulatory costs by ensuring regulation is fit for purpose, proportionate and adaptive.

The department is expected to actively contribute to the government's regulatory reform and productivity agenda by:

- adjusting its regulatory posture and risk appetite where appropriate to create a regulatory environment that supports economic growth and productivity by better balancing risk mitigation with efficiency, growth and dynamism
- identifying priority areas against which to progress reforms that reduce regulatory burden and improve efficiency, including through appropriate opportunities to improve and streamline regulatory processes
- supporting cross-government initiatives to modernise regulation, including through digital transformation and AI-enabled systems.

In doing so the department should also address the regulatory reform ideas it proposed in its response (31 July 2025) to the joint letter from the Treasurer and Minister for Finance (4 July 2025) and outline how progress will be tracked and reported.

Regulatory Policy, Practice and Performance Framework principles

The department is expected to align its regulatory approach and implementation with the government's *Regulatory Policy, Practice and Performance Framework*³. This supports the APS Reform Agenda and aims to modernise regulation, improve productivity, and build trust in government. The framework includes 6 principles that set the standard for designing, implementing, managing, and evaluating regulation to ensure it is fit-for-purpose. The framework's 6 principles should also be applied by the department in the context of its operating environment, the global regulatory landscape, and its obligation to make lawful, evidence-based regulatory decisions.

The department is expected to continually monitor and engage with other regulators including international regulatory bodies (as appropriate) to ensure its regulatory approaches keep pace with best practice, technology advances, global standards, industry practices and community expectations.

Regulatory performance and reporting

The department should take an evidence-based approach to measuring its regulatory performance, the impact of its regulatory activities, and to support continuous improvement.

This includes:

- clearly defining regulatory roles and responsibilities, understanding and addressing regulatory risks proportionately and having regulatory performance measurement and reporting frameworks in place, as set out in RMG 128
- incorporating regulator performance reporting into the Department's corporate planning process and annual reporting as required by RMG 128 and under the PGPA Act and the *Public Governance, Performance and Accountability Rule 2014*, to support greater transparency and accountability of regulator performance.

Relationship with the Minister and portfolio

The department plays an essential role in ensuring that the government is well placed to respond promptly to any policy challenges and opportunities arising from these regulatory frameworks.

Accordingly, the department is expected to provide considered, evidence-based and timely policy advice on significant issues relating to these regulatory frameworks, in accordance with the government's policy priorities and objectives.

³ Available on the Department of Finance's [website](#), Whole-of-government Regulatory Policy, Practice & Performance Framework

With respect to the portfolio regulators and their independence as statutory authorities, I expect the department will work closely with these agencies to ensure a joined-up approach, while advancing and sharing best practice regulation.

As the responsible Minister, I will continue to ensure the department is well informed of the government's policy direction as specific initiatives and strategies are being considered.

The department's regulatory responsibilities are central to Australia's productivity growth, economic resilience and public confidence in government. I look forward to working cooperatively with the you to deliver regulatory systems that achieve their objectives and are modern, trusted and ease the regulatory burden for businesses across the agricultural sector.